CHANDRADEEP KUMAR





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BIG FIGHT Chief minister Jairam Thakur at the BJP headquarters in Delhi; state Congress chief Pratibha Singh addressing a rally at Keylong

Sabha perch. To keep that momentum alive, the role of Virbhadra's widow, Pratibha Singh, is quite crucial. So, this April, the Congress made her state unit chief, placating her arch foes Mukesh Agnihotri and Sukhwinder Sukhu with key posts (presently leader of the opposition and campaign committee chief, respectively).

But things turned sour when Pratibha made son and Shimla Rural MLA Vikramaditya Singh in-charge of the yatra, the party's main campaign vehicle this time. The party leadership in Delhi, burnt by the factionalism in neighbouring Uttarakhand and Punjab, had to intervene—Vikramaditya was eased out, his mother given the chariot reins, Agnihotri and Sukhu brought on board. A subtle signal of equivalence, reflecting how the Congress has refrained from naming a CM candidate.

There's no defeatism, though, as in other states. No party has won a second consecutive term in Himachal for decades, and the Congress could use a morale-booster. Nor would it harm general secretary Priyanka Gandhi after the debacles in Uttar Pradesh and Punjab. She is heading the party's campaign. Ashutosh Kumar, who teaches political science at Panjab University, says, "In 2017, the Congress vote was down by just 1.1 per cent; the BJP won by taking smaller parties' votes. It will be tough."

As for the BJP, the central leadership has clarified that Chief Minister Jairam Thakur will remain the party's face in the assembly polls, though he's seen as a novice administrator. This has led to some heartburn in rival groups led by ex-CMs Prem Kumar Dhumal and Shanta Kumar. Dhumal loyalist Khimi Ram, a former state unit chief, has joined the Congress. The buzz is, a few more local leaders could follow. Himachal is also BJP president J.P. Nadda's home ground, so it's a prestige battle for him.

The Dhumal lobby wanted Union minister Anurag Thakur to replace Jairam, a move scuttled by Nadda with the backing of PM Narendra Modi. They are also sulking at the induction of two independents hitherto hostile to them. The Congress is trying to cash in on all this disaffection by bringing home some of the brighter names. Indu Verma, wife of former BJP MLA Rakesh Verma, is already on board. The buzz is, Ravi could follow too. The BJP is fighting poaching with poaching: on August 17, it inducted Kangra MLA Pawan Kajal, ex-Congress state chief, its OBC face and a key man in Pratibha's team. As for the Aam Aadmi Party, which had hoped for its March triumph in Punjab to spill over, it made a disastrous start: its entire state unit in April had to be disbanded after many of its leaders, including its state chief, joined the BJP. For AAP, Himachal looks all uphill. ■

HOW HIMACHAL HAS VOTED

TOTAL ASSEMBLY SEATS: **68**

